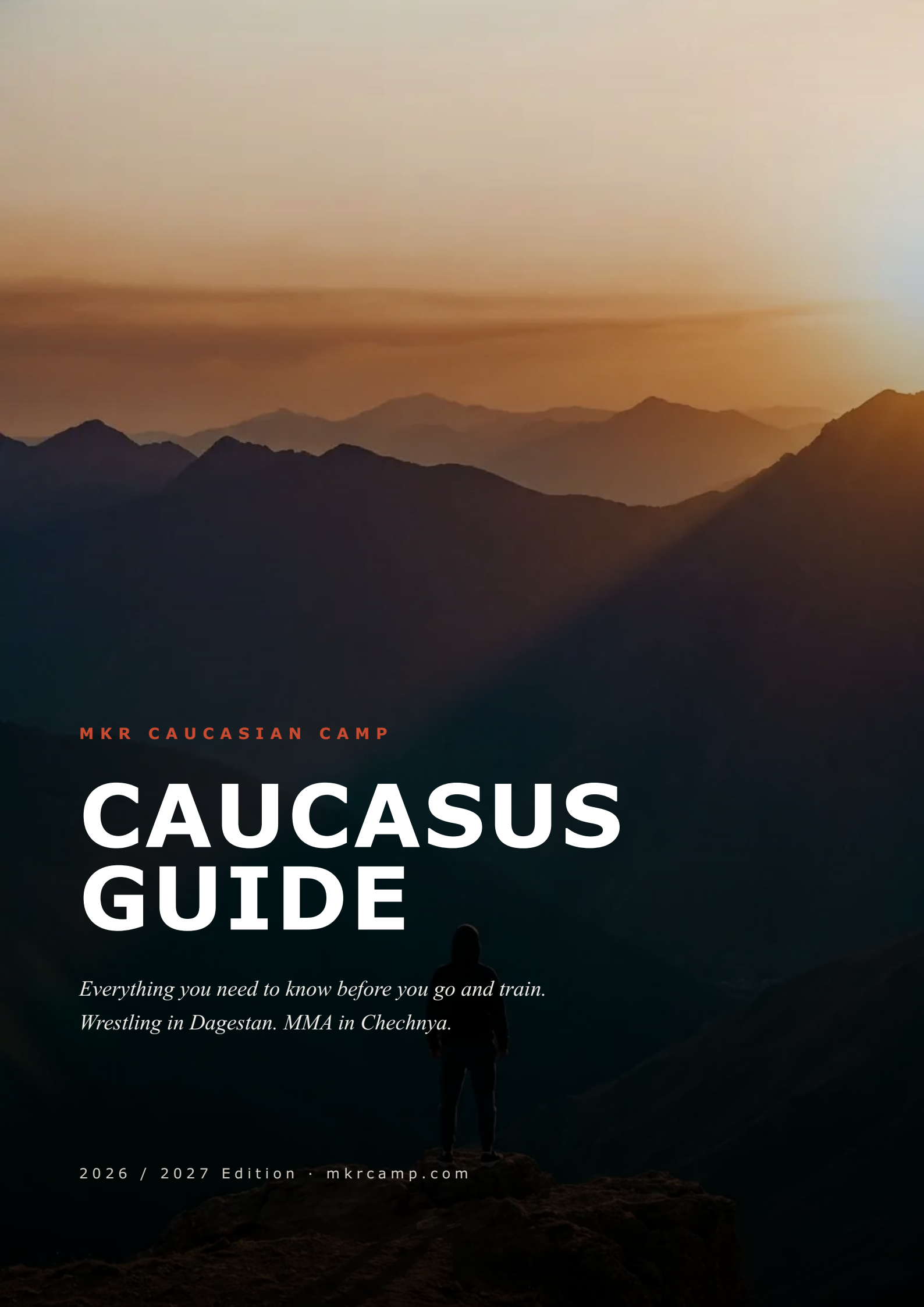


A person stands on a rocky peak, looking out over a vast mountain range under a sunset sky. The person is silhouetted against the bright orange and yellow light of the setting sun. The mountains in the background are layered, creating a sense of depth. The overall mood is serene and majestic.

MKR CAUCASIAN CAMP

CAUCASUS GUIDE

Everything you need to know before you go and train.

Wrestling in Dagestan. MMA in Chechnya.

2026 / 2027 Edition • mkrcamp.com

PREFACE

YOU ARE READING THIS BECAUSE YOU ARE SERIOUSLY THINKING ABOUT IT.

This is the guide I wish I had before my first trip. Instead, I struggled with the visa, took the wrong flight, spent twice what I should have. I went anyway. Without a guide.

My name is Ruslan Mukhtarov. I grew up between Lille and Makhachkala. My mother is French, my father is Dagestani. Half of my summers were spent on a wrestling mat in Kaspiysk, among cousins who have been wrestling since they could walk.

This dual background is useful: I see both sides. I see why a French fighter who wants to come and train here keeps running into the same walls every time. The visa that drags on. The insurance that does not cover Russia. The flight booked badly. The budget that is underestimated. The doubt the night before departure, when you wonder what you have gotten yourself into.

MKR Caucasian Camp exists to solve all of that. **We handle the visa from A to Z** (application, invitation letter, submission, follow-up). We organize domestic flights Istanbul to Makhachkala or Istanbul to Grozny. We take care of accommodation, transfers, local coaches, gyms.

You give us three documents and you only have one thing left to do: train.

What you will read in the following pages is the rest. The things you will not find on any forum, because you have to have lived them to know. The physical preparation that actually works. The culture you must respect so you do not come across as a tourist. The five mistakes guys make every month, the ones we try to stop them from making again.

Read it through. Keep it on your desk. Come back to it when you doubt.

RUSLAN MUKHTAROV

FOUNDER, MKR CAUCASIAN CAMP

CONTENTS

WHAT YOU WILL FIND INSIDE.

The Caucasus in numbers	p. 04
DAGESTAN Why wrestling dominates the world here	p. 06
CHECHNYA Why MMA exploded here	p. 07
Russian visa: what nobody tells you	p. 08
Flights: the route that works	p. 10
Budget: the real numbers	p. 12
Physical preparation in six weeks	p. 13
Mental preparation	p. 15
Equipment: the honest list	p. 16
On site: a typical day	p. 17
Culture and immersion	p. 18
Stories from alumni	p. 19
Next steps	p. 20

THE CAUCASUS IN NUMBERS.

Two republics of the Russian Federation, neighbors, distinct. Half of the North Caucasus that has produced, on its own, more world champions in combat sports than entire countries.

3.1 M

DAGESTAN POPULATION

1.5 M

CHECHNYA POPULATION

50,300

KM² DAGESTAN

17,200

KM² CHECHNYA

~1,000

M AVERAGE ALTITUDE

+30

LANGUAGES SPOKEN

Dagestan is the densest ethnic mosaic in the world. Avars, Lezgins, Dargins, Laks, Tabasarans, Kumyks. About thirty peoples, almost as many languages, and Russian as the common tongue. Chechnya is more uniform: the Chechen language dominates, Islam structures the rhythm of daily life.

Both republics are Sunni Muslim, hospitable by tradition, demanding by culture. You do not cheat on a wrestling mat here. You come to work, or you do not come.

WHY THESE TWO LANDS FOR MKR.

DAGESTAN

Capital Makhachkala, a coastal city on the Caspian Sea. This is where you come for wrestling. Gyms in Makhachkala and Kaspiysk, the cradle of the Dagestani school.

- **Abdulrashid Sadulaev**: two-time Olympic champion, four-time world freestyle wrestling champion
- **Buvaisar Saitiev**: three-time Olympic champion, six-time world champion, considered the greatest freestyle wrestler of all time
- **Khabib Nurmagomedov** and **Islam Makhachev**: UFC champions formed on the same mats

CHECHNYA

Capital Grozny, a city rebuilt since 2009. New skyscrapers, the Akhmad Kadyrov Mosque visible from kilometers away, modern sports facilities. This is where you come for MMA.

- **Akhmat Fight Club**: opened in 2014, become in ten years the regional MMA factory. Head coach Murad Bichuev.
- **Khamzat Chimaev**: the current international showcase. He trains here when he returns home.
- More than a hundred pro fighters pass through Chechen gyms each year.

One official MKR session = one discipline = one destination. You want to do both? We switch to Custom Camp (X days Dagestan + Y days Chechnya, à la carte).

A photograph of a wrestling gym with a high wooden truss ceiling. In the foreground, two male wrestlers in black singlets are in a low, ready stance, facing each other. In the background, another pair of wrestlers is visible, one in a blue singlet and one in a red singlet, also in a ready stance. The gym floor is blue and red.

DAGESTAN · WRESTLING

THE COUNTRY THAT PRODUCED THE BEST WRESTLERS IN THE WORLD.

Ask any coach from Iran, the United States or Russia: "Where do the toughest wrestlers come from?" You will always get the same answer, without a second of hesitation.



CHECHNYA · MMA

A YOUNG SCHOOL ALREADY GLOBAL.

In 2014, Akhmat Fight Club opened its doors in Grozny. Ten years later, dozens of its fighters compete in the UFC, Bellator, ONE. No region in the world has progressed so fast, so recently, in the discipline.

RUSSIAN VISA: WE HANDLE IT.

This is probably the first thing that worried you when you read "going to train in Russia." Good. Now you can forget about it. The visa is the piece that MKR takes care of for every participant. From A to Z.

WHAT MKR DOES FOR YOU

- ☐ **Eligibility check** based on your nationality (FR, CH, BE, CA, and others). We confirm the right path (Russian e-visa or traditional visa) during the kickoff call.
- ☐ **Issuance of the official invitation letter** within 5 business days after your validation.
- ☐ **Preparation and review of the application** on the official site evisa.kdmid.ru or with the consulate / VFS Global / TLScontact depending on your country.
- ☐ **Follow-up on the submission and processing time.** If the center drags, we push. If a document is rejected, we tell you before your file gets blocked.
- ☐ **Visa retrieval** in PDF format (e-visa) or physical in your passport (traditional visa). We confirm everything before your flight.

WHAT YOU PROVIDE

Three documents, that is all. We send you a personalized checklist by email after the kickoff call.

- ☐ **Color scan of your passport**, valid 6 months minimum after your return date, two blank pages available
- ☐ **Digital ID photo**, white background, no glasses, ≤ 5 MB in JPEG. We tell you exactly how to take it if you struggle.
- ☐ **Travel insurance certificate** covering Russia (see below)

INSURANCE: THE TRAP TO AVOID

Since February 2022, most European insurance policies exclude Russia. A premium credit card insurance is no longer systematically sufficient. During the kickoff call, we recommend two or three contracts that actually work (Mondial Assistance Russie, AXA Assistance, Allianz Travel) based on your profile. It is a moderate cost, to plan separately.

THE VISA SCHEDULE WITH MKR

DAY	ACTION	SIDE
D-60	MKR validation call, we confirm your visa path	Together
D-55	We issue your official invitation letter	MKR
D-50	You send us the 3 documents (passport, photo, insurance)	You
D-45	We prepare and review your complete file	MKR
D-40	Online submission (e-visa) or in-center (traditional visa)	MKR with you
D-35	Visa received and confirmed	MKR to You
D 0	You board, visa in hand	You

The schedule above is our standard. If you validate late (less than 45 days before the session), we switch to express mode. For ultra-urgent cases (less than 20 days), we study case by case.

WHY WE STILL TELL YOU ABOUT IT

Because you will be carrying your passport, your letter, your printed visa to customs. And it is you who answers the Russian customs officer's questions (in simple English, never in French). You need to understand what you are presenting.

THE TWO PATHS, CLEARLY

- ☐ **Russian e-visa:** official processing within 4 business days, maximum stay 30 days, validity 120 days from issuance. Suitable for almost all MKR sessions.
- ☐ **Traditional visa:** submission at VFS Global or TLScontact center, processing 5 to 15 business days, stay depending on requested duration. Reserved for long stays or multiple entries.
- ☐ **MKR coverage:** process and fees included in your package, regardless of the chosen path. You front nothing.

Stuck despite everything? Tell us right away. We have already unblocked about thirty cases in two years. One phone call to the right number almost always does the trick.

FLIGHTS. THE ROUTE THAT WORKS.

Since the 2022 sanctions, no direct flight links the Schengen area to Makhachkala or Grozny. All routes go through Istanbul, the pivot point between the two worlds. It is the only reliable passage, and it is the one we take for you.

ROUTE BY DISCIPLINE

WRESTLING

Your city to Istanbul to Makhachkala (code MCX). International flight 3 to 6 hours depending on the departure. Istanbul layover 2 to 6 hours. Domestic flight Istanbul to Makhachkala 3 hours, operated by Turkish Airlines or Pegasus. Domestic flight included in your MKR package.

MMA

Your city to Istanbul to Grozny (code GRV). Same pattern. Domestic flight Istanbul to Grozny 2 h 50, operated by Turkish Airlines. Domestic flight included in your MKR package.

PREFERRED AIRLINES

AIRLINE	DEPARTURE CITIES	ISTANBUL AIRPORT
Turkish Airlines	CDG, GVA, BRU, LYS, MRS	IST (European side)
Pegasus Airlines	CDG, ORY, GVA, BSL	SAW (Asian side)
Air France • Swiss	CDG, GVA	IST

Watch out. Pegasus arrives at Sabiha Gökçen (SAW, Asian side), Turkish Airlines at Istanbul Airport (IST, European side). An hour and a half by taxi separates the two. If you connect IST to SAW for your domestic flight, you need a 4-hour layover minimum.

BEST PRACTICES

- ☐ **Book 90 days before your departure.** Beyond that, prices climb fast, especially on Turkish.
- ☐ **Plan a return 1 or 2 days after the end of the camp.** Your body needs a buffer, and a 7 a.m. flight after three weeks of double sessions is brutal.
- ☐ **Check the baggage allowance.** Turkish: 23 kg checked included. Pegasus: 20 kg, and only if you take the option at booking (otherwise a steep surcharge at the airport).
- ☐ **Get cancellation insurance.** Visa Premier and Mastercard Gold cards often cover, but with caps. If your round trip exceeds the card caps, get a dedicated contract.
- ☐ **4-hour layover minimum in Istanbul if you change airports.** An hour and a half by taxi between IST and SAW, plus exit to the public zone, plus re-entry through security. Plan wide.

CHARACTERISTICS OF EACH SEASON

PERIOD	CLIMATE	ATMOSPHERE
Summer 2026 (mid-August, mid-September)	Dry, hot, up to 30 °C in Makhachkala	Peak activity, full gyms, many internationals
Fall 2026 (October, November)	Mild by day, cool at night, first winds	Good weather compromise, studious atmosphere
Winter 2027 (February, March)	Dry cold, snow at altitude, bright sun	Fewer people, raw atmosphere, maximum focus
Spring 2027 (April)	Very pleasant, mountains thawing	Spring restart, beautiful excursion landscapes

During the validation kickoff call, we look at flight options together. No commission, no pressure. Just the experience of about fifty camps already organized.

WHAT IS INCLUDED. WHAT IS NOT.

The MKR package covers everything related to the camp itself. You handle the international travel and your personal expenses. Here is the split, no gray areas.

INCLUDED IN YOUR PACKAGE

- ☐ **Domestic flight Istanbul to Makhachkala** (Wrestling) or **Istanbul to Grozny** (MMA), round trip
- ☐ **Airport transfers to camp** on arrival and departure
- ☐ **Full accommodation** for the duration of your stay
- ☐ **Two hot meals per day** prepared on site
- ☐ **Two training sessions per day, six days a week**
- ☐ **Coaching by local coaches** in partner gyms
- ☐ **Full visa coverage** from A to Z (process and fees)
- ☐ **Cultural excursion** optional on Sunday (Gamsutl, Sulak, Kadyrov Mosque)

ON YOU, IN ADDITION TO THE PACKAGE

- ☐ **International round trip flight** from your city to Istanbul
- ☐ **Travel insurance** covering Russia (mandatory, we recommend reliable contracts during the kickoff call)
- ☐ **Personal equipment** (see chapter 07)
- ☐ **Pocket money:** external meals, laundry, city transport, souvenirs

The exact price of your package depends on the format (solo, duo, trio, club, family) and the duration (1, 2 or 3 weeks). We detail it during the kickoff call, after reading your file.

SIX WEEKS TO ARRIVE READY.

The MKR rhythm is two sessions per day, six days a week, in immersion. If you arrive cold, you break on day four and spend the rest of the camp in recovery. Here is the protocol that works, tested across three years of alumni feedback.

WEEKS 1 AND 2 · CARDIO REBUILD

Your aerobic base is your first weapon. If it gives out, nothing else holds.

- ☐ **3 cardio sessions per week**, jogging 30 to 45 minutes, conversational pace. You should be able to talk while running.
- ☐ **2 dynamic mobility sessions** of 30 minutes. Hips, shoulders, thoracic spine. Less glamorous than lifting, this is what keeps you on the mat.
- ☐ **1 deep core session**. Plank 4 times 45 seconds, hollow rocks 3 times 20, side plank 3 times 30 seconds per side.
- ☐ Goal: wake up your aerobic system without burning it.

WEEKS 3 AND 4 · FUNCTIONAL STRENGTH

Now you load. Compound movements only. No bicep curls, no isolated calves.

- ☐ **2 heavy strength sessions**. Squat, deadlift, weighted pull-ups, dips. 4 to 5 sets of 4 to 6 reps, progressive loads.
- ☐ **2 cardio sessions** including one interval. Format 8 to 10 reps of 1 minute hard followed by 1 minute easy. On treadmill, road or bike, indifferent.
- ☐ **1 technical session** in your main sport. Drilling, controlled situations, light sparring if possible. No war.
- ☐ Goal: absorb the volume without injuring yourself.

WEEK 5 · SPECIFIC ENDURANCE

You simulate the cumulative fatigue of the camp. Three days in a row at high intensity, then one full off day.

- ☐ **3 high-intensity sessions** as circuits. Burpees, kettlebell swings, short sprints, dynamic planks. 5 rounds of 4 minutes effort / 1 minute rest.
- ☐ **2 sessions of your sport** at progressive intensity. Intensive drilling, sparring situations, transitions.
- ☐ **1 full off day.** Walking, sauna, massage. No intense movement.
- ☐ Goal: prepare the nervous system for the camp load.

WEEK 6 · TAPER

The week before departure, you cut the volume but keep the intensity. Classic mistake: keep pushing hard until the last day. You arrive cooked, you waste your first week of camp.

- ☐ **Volume reduced by 40%** across all sessions.
- ☐ **Intensity maintained but sessions short.** 25 minutes instead of 50.
- ☐ **Technical work alone** in your sport. No hard sparring. You have nothing left to prove to your club.
- ☐ **Sleep 8 to 9 hours per night.** Non-negotiable.
- ☐ Goal: arrive fresh, not cooked.

IF YOU GO TO WRESTLING IN DAGESTAN

Reinforce your lower back, posterior chain, hips. Drill stop-outs, ground transitions, long-duration aerobic cardio. In Kaspiysk, you wrestle three times a day if you can keep up.

IF YOU GO TO MMA IN CHECHNYA

Keep volume on striking and ground defense. Work on standing / ground transitions. Mixed cardio. In Grozny, sessions integrate more short explosive circuits.

THE PREPARATION NOBODY TELLS YOU ABOUT.

The body holds if you have prepared it. The head is another matter. Here are the five shocks to prepare for now, so you do not discover them over there, ten thousand kilometers from home.

1. ISOLATION

No family. No friends. No routine. No smooth FaceTime (local 4G is decent but the latency is rough). The first 48 hours, you feel lost. That is normal. Accept it. From day 3, you enter another temporality, slower, fuller.

2. CULTURE SHOCK

Five prayers a day. No alcohol in public. Modest dress code expected for women (shoulders and knees covered). For men: crew-neck t-shirts, shorts below the knee in town. Respect, observe, ask open questions. Dagestanis and Chechens judge you on two things: your manners and your work on the mat. The rest, they do not care.

3. CUMULATIVE FATIGUE

On day five or six, you will hit a wall. Your body demands a break you will not give it. It passes. By day eight, you climb back up, and you see what is changing. Anticipate this moment, do not fear it. The worst moment of the camp is never the last day, it is always the fifth.

4. THE EGO TAKES A HIT

You will get dominated by fifteen-year-old kids. It is their job since they could stand. No reproach, no contempt, just a fact. Leave your ego at the airport. Learn.

5. THE RETURN

You come back transformed. Your circle has not moved. The gap is harder than expected. Plan a 48-hour buffer before going back to work or telling everyone about your camp. You will need to digest in silence.

THE HONEST LIST.

The strict minimum, not a gram more. Everything below is also available on site, but at Russian prices (which are not always lower for imported brands). Pack your bag, close it, do not come back to it.

CLOTHING AND PROTECTION

- ☐ 2 training shorts
- ☐ 3 compression t-shirts
- ☐ 1 long-sleeve rashguard
- ☐ Wrestling: 2 pairs of wrestling shoes suited for soft mats
- ☐ MMA: 1 pair of boxing shoes plus shin guards
- ☐ Thermoformable mouthguard
- ☐ MMA: personal 4 oz gloves mandatory (we do not lend)
- ☐ Groin protector
- ☐ 1 decent civilian outfit for outings (long pants, polo)

HYGIENE AND ADMINISTRATIVE

- ☐ Basic care kit (neutral soap, toothbrush, painkiller, anti-diarrheal)
- ☐ Sport adhesive tape in quantity, you will not find the quality on site
- ☐ USB cable plus external battery (power cuts still exist)
- ☐ Notebook and pen for the personal end-of-day debrief
- ☐ Paper copies of passport, e-visa printed in two copies, insurance certificate

If you go for Wrestling: **no kimono**, we work in singlet or compression. If you go for MMA: **MMA gloves** mandatory in luggage, we do not provide and we do not lend.

A TYPICAL DAY.

Here is what a Tuesday at the camp looks like. The pace is demanding but not absurd. It is precisely this volume that transforms you in three weeks.

TIME	ACTIVITY	NOTE
7:30	Wake up and light breakfast	Coffee, dried fruits, eggs, flatbread
8:30 to 10:00	Aerobic run or mobility	Base work, never sprints
10:30 to 12:30	Session 1 Wrestling (Dagestan)	Drilling, situations, controlled sparring
11:00 to 13:00	Session 1 MMA (Chechnya)	Striking, grappling, transitions
13:00 to 14:30	First hot meal	Traditional dish, rice, meat, vegetables
14:30 to 17:00	Recovery, nap, care	Essential, not optional
17:30 to 19:30	Session 2 Wrestling (Dagestan)	Technical work, situational sparring
18:00 to 20:00	Session 2 MMA (Chechnya)	Conditioning, controlled sparring
20:30	Second meal	Soup, main course, herbal tea
22:00	Lights out	Deep sleep non-negotiable

Friday evening and Saturday morning: lighter day, collective prayer if you wish. Sunday: optional excursion or full rest. In Kaspiysk, we sometimes go up to the village of Gamsutl. In Grozny, we visit the mosque.

IMMERSE, DO NOT OBSERVE.

The Caucasus has its codes and enforces them. The difference between a respected visitor and a tolerated visitor is decided in the first 48 hours. Here is what you need to know before you arrive.

A FEW WORDS TO KNOW

Salam alaykum · the universal Muslim greeting, understood everywhere

Wa alaykum salam · the response

Rakhmat · thank you (Avar, main language of Dagestan)

Barkalla · thank you (Chechen)

Spasibo · thank you in Russian, understood everywhere

Da · Niet · yes · no in Russian

Kharasho · it is good, it works

Davai · come on, go, hang in there

RELIGION AND SOCIAL CODE

Islam structures both republics. Five daily prayers, no alcohol in public, modest dress code expected, especially for women (shoulders and knees covered). During Ramadan, you eat and drink discreetly during the day. The handshake is firm, the gaze is direct but without challenge.

When you are invited into someone's home, you take off your shoes at the entrance. Always. It is the gesture that changes everything.

THE CUISINE, WHAT YOU WILL EAT

- ☐ **Khinkali**: dumplings with minced meat, broth trapped inside. You grab by the "hat" (the twist), bite a corner, suck the juice, eat the rest, throw away the hat. It is non-negotiable.
- ☐ **Chudu**: thin flatbread stuffed with meat, cheese or herbs. Quintessential Dagestani specialty, sharing dish.
- ☐ **Urbech**: paste of ground seeds (flax, sesame, apricot). Energetic, dense, perfect at breakfast. Hard to bring back in luggage, so enjoy it on site.
- ☐ **Shashlik**: grilled meat skewers, convivial evening dish. Mutton, beef, sometimes sturgeon on the Caspian coast.
- ☐ **Chak-chak**: confectionery of honey and fried dough. You try it at least once.
- ☐ **Very sweet black tea**: serves everywhere, all the time. Refusing is a mild offense.

THEY HAVE BEEN THROUGH IT.

Two testimonials from pro fighters who did MKR. They tell it better than we do.

At the start I was hesitating. I did not know anyone there, I did not speak a word of Russian, I was stressed about the visa. MKR handled everything. Three days after arriving in Kaspiysk, I was sparring with a former European freestyle wrestling champion who was correcting my stop-outs. I came back with fifteen years of progression compressed into three weeks.

ANTOINE PETIT-JEAN • PROFESSIONAL MMA FIGHTER, DAGESTAN 2025 SESSION

What struck me was the rigor. The coaches do not let go, they correct constantly, they see details no one in France had ever pointed out. And behind the rigor, there is real kindness. You do not feel tested, you feel prepared. I will be back this year.

LAMP • PROFESSIONAL MMA FIGHTER, DAGESTAN 2025 SESSION

More testimonials, videos and written, on mkrcamp.com/temoignages. All sessions are filmed by default, you leave with an edit.

NEXT STEPS

YOU ARE READY. NOW CHOOSE.

THE FOUR OFFICIAL SESSIONS 2026 / 2027

Summer 2026

August 17 to September 5

Fall 2026

October 17 to November 7

Winter 2027

February 13 to March 6

Spring 2027

April 3 to 24

APPLY NOW

Five minutes online at mkrcamp.com/inscription. No immediate payment. Manual validation by video call with Ruslan Mukhtarov within 48 hours, then bank details sent for payment by transfer.

TO TALK RIGHT AWAY

WhatsApp **+33 6 66 17 76 91**

Email **contact@mkrcamp.com**

Instagram **[@mkrcamp](https://www.instagram.com/mkrcamp)**

Caucasus Guide, May 2026 edition. Regular updates at mkrcamp.com/guide-caucase.

MKR Caucasian Camp · Wrestling and MMA training camps at the heart of the Caucasus.